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Crisis Comms

The First 24 Hours of a Crisis

A playbook for SMEs



Raise It With Press Release

swipe →

0–1h

Confirm, Don't Speculate

Get the facts from the people closest to the issue. Name **one spokesperson** and one approver. Everyone else stays off the record.

1–3h

A Holding Statement

Short beats perfect. Say what you know, what you're doing and when the next update comes.

example

"We are aware of (issue). Our priority is (people/customers). We are (action). We will share an update by (time) today."

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3–6h

Bahasa and English, Same Message

In Malaysia your audience reads in more than one language. Publish the statement in BM and English at the same time, with identical facts, so no version looks like it is hiding something.

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37%

of Malaysians trust most news most of the time

Low trust means rumours move fast. A clear, sourced statement from you gives journalists something solid to quote.

Source: Reuters Institute, Digital News Report 2025

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6–24h

Update on the Clock You Promised

Miss your own deadline and the story becomes about silence. Update even if the update is "investigation ongoing, next update at 10am".

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Don't, Ever

- ✕ "No comment"
- ✕ Deleting critical comments
- ✕ Blaming a junior staffer in public
- ✕ Guessing numbers before they are confirmed

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Speak First, With Facts. It's Worked Since 1906.

1. Save this playbook
2. Share it with your management team
3. Prepare a holding statement template today

Source:
· Reuters Institute, Digital News Report 2025
· Billy Penn (2023) on Ivy Lee, 1906